

MAIN CHALLENGER
Former PM and PTI chief Imran Khan at an Islamabad court in May 2023. In August he was convicted and put behind bars

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the public's short memory. It has seen how the public anger against Imran Khan's government dissipated over time after his ouster, as further crises unfolded, and focused instead on the Shehbaz Sharif-led government.

This is also one of the reasons why the elections have been delayed for so long. The PML-N would like to put as much distance and time between them and the Shehbaz Sharif-led coalition government that took over after Imran Khan's ouster and which had to take certain unpopular decisions to revive the IMF programme sabotaged by the outgoing government. The PML-N leadership has repeatedly said that the choice in front of them when the Pakistan Democratic Movement's (PDM) coalition government took over in April 2022 was either to save Pakistan from default or to save their politics and that they chose to bite the bullet and took the former route, at the cost of losing their political capital. However true it may be, such rhetoric does not resonate with the masses suffering from the crushing effects on their own stomachs and bank balances.

STIFF CHALLENGES

Nawaz Sharif, who has been around in Pakistan politics now for 40 years, understands this. Whether he is able to change the popular narrative before the elections remains to be seen. But he also has some other stiff challenges in front of him. The first among them is the judicial one. Although he has received a reprieve from being arrested, he still must

AVENFIELD APARTMENTS CASE: It was alleged that Sharif's children used laundered money through firms based in the British Virgin Islands to buy the expensive London apartments. The Sharifs said they bought them through the proceeds from the sale of a steel firm in UAE. However, in July 2018, the court sentenced Sharif to 10 years in jail, and Maryam and her husband to seven years and one year in jail. respectively. In September 2018, the Sharifs got a reprieve when the Islamabad High Court ordered their release pending appeals.

AL-AZIZIA CASE: The Accountability Court held that Sharif couldn't satisfactorily explain as to how he had set up the Al Azizia Steel Mills and Hill Metal establishment in Saudi Arabia. He was sentenced to jail for seven years in this case, and was serving this when he fell ill, leading to a suspension of his term for eight weeks on medical grounds. He then went to the UK for treatment. In 2020, he was declared a 'proclaimed offender' in both cases.

OTHER CASES: In the illegal plot allotment case, Sharif is accused of allotting plots to people misusing his authority, and breaking rules to construct a road to his house in Lahore. In the illegal share transfer case, he is accused of transferring shares of the family-owned Chaudhry Sugar Mills unlawfully. And, in the Toshakhana Case—similar to that under which former PM Imran Khan was convicted—Sharif allegedly acquired luxury cars from the national treasury in violation of the rules. In 2020, the court issued a non-bailable warrant and declared him a 'proclaimed offender' in this case.